

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN EGYPT

Complete Community Opposition How-To

A practical guide for communities facing destructive development projects in Egypt, grounded in the Environment Law and its EIA system, the Egyptian Environmental Affairs Agency, the licensing role of the competent administrative authority, and the administrative courts of the State Council

This guide uses the Egyptian legal terms you will actually encounter (Law 4/1994 and its Executive Regulations, the EEAA, the competent administrative authority, the Category A / B / C screening tiers, the environmental approval, the Permanent Appeals Committee, and the Administrative Court of the State Council — the Majlis al-Dawla), each explained in plain language where it first comes up.

A note on terms. Important terms are shown in **bold** the first time they appear, with a plain-language explanation right where they come up. Where a term is Egyptian, the everyday word is used alongside it.

A note on realism, up front. Egypt's environmental law is real and usable: every significant project needs an environmental assessment before it is licensed, and a citizen can challenge a decision in the administrative courts. But the space to organise is narrow. The associations law tightly controls what civil-society groups may do and how they may be funded, assembly is restricted, and many of the largest projects are driven by the state itself, sometimes by bodies that are difficult to challenge. This guide treats those facts as the terrain, not as a reason to give up — it steers you toward the levers that still work, and is honest about the ones that do not.

A note on safety. In Egypt, opposing a project can carry personal risk, especially where the state or the military is the developer. Nothing in this guide is worth harm to you. Prefer the routes that are documentary and lawful — the assessment file, the administrative complaint, the court case, the professional syndicate — over anything that exposes named individuals. Read Section 13 before you act if the project is state-driven.

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INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Why This Matters

Egypt builds at enormous scale and speed — desert cities, Red Sea and Mediterranean resorts, roads and bridges through established neighbourhoods, industrial zones, power plants, quarries, and vast projects on and around the Nile. Much of it is driven from the top, and much is genuinely transformative for the people where it lands: homes demolished, narrow-strip Nile farmland built over, islands and lakeshores cleared, coasts hardened, air and water degraded. When people ask

whether anything can be done, the honest answer is: **sometimes, and more often than they expect — but only if they use the specific machinery the law provides and understand where it stops.**

That machinery exists. Under **Law 4/1994 for the Protection of the Environment** — amended by Law 9/2009 and Law 105/2015, with **Executive Regulations** since 1995 — **Article 19 requires every natural or legal person, public or private, to submit a study of their project's environmental impact to the licensing body before the work begins.** That is the single most important sentence in this guide. An assessment done *after* a facility is built does not satisfy the law and can expose it to closure. The requirement is a real gate, and the moment before a project passes through it is when your community has the most power.

The system is run by the **Egyptian Environmental Affairs Agency (EEAA)** — the national regulator, now under the Ministry of Environment — which sets the rules, screens projects into tiers, and reviews the studies. Projects are screened by likely severity into **Category A** (minor impact, lightest assessment), **Category B** (more significant, a fuller assessment), and **Category C** (greatest potential impact, requiring a complete Environmental Impact Assessment). **Arguing that a project has been screened into too low a category is one of the most effective objections available**, because the category determines how much scrutiny — and disclosure — it receives.

And there is a real appeal route. A project owner who objects to an EEAA decision goes to a **Permanent Appeals Committee**, which must decide within a set period; more importantly for you, **decisions of that committee can be challenged before the Administrative Court of the State Council** — the *Majlis al-Dawla*, Egypt's dedicated administrative-law judiciary, which reviews the legality of government decisions and has a genuine record of annulling them. Egypt's own environmental law also gives **any concerned citizen or entity the right, under Article 103, to report a violation to the competent public authorities**, including the prosecution.

The honest counterweight, stated plainly. Egypt's civic space is heavily constrained. The associations law — **Law 149 of 2019** — and its regulations place independent civil-society groups under close state and security supervision, restrict their activities, and make foreign funding difficult; human-rights bodies describe it as bringing NGOs under near-total state control. Assembly is tightly regulated. Many of the biggest projects are built by the state, the armed forces' economic arms, or bodies hard to reach in court. And the courts, while genuinely independent in many administrative matters, operate within those limits. None of this makes opposition pointless — but it changes which tools work, and it means the **documentary and legal routes matter far more here than street mobilisation**, which can be dangerous.

What "winning" realistically means. Rarely the outright, permanent cancellation of a flagship state project. More often: a private or investor-driven project **relocated** off a sensitive site; a coastal or Nile-side scheme **redesigned** to cut its footprint; an assessment **redone** properly after being exposed as inadequate; **conditions, mitigation and monitoring** written into the environmental approval; a project **delayed** while the assessment is contested; a demolition or eviction **paused or compensated** after legal challenge; a quarry, factory or dump **refused or moved**. The realistic goal is to make a project smaller, better-sited, better-mitigated, slower, or — for genuinely private developments on clearly unlawful ground — stopped.

The Strategic Framework

Five steps that reinforce each other:

1. **Target identification** — establish the developer, the licensing authority, and the assessment category.
2. **Documentation** — build a technical and legal record strong enough for the EEAA and the administrative court.
3. **Local opposition** — organise carefully and lawfully, using the channels that are open.
4. **Legal challenges** — the assessment, the licence, and the State Council.
5. **Media strategy** — coverage that raises the cost of a visibly unlawful or damaging decision.

No single step wins alone. Here the combination that works is **a rigorous objection to the environmental assessment, carried into the administrative court by people with standing.**

Critical Caveat: A Tilted System Can Make Opposition Harder (But Doesn't Make It Impossible)

Egypt's system is tilted toward development and toward the state, and organising is constrained by law. Assessing that honestly is what lets you pick the right tools: the strongest routes here are **the mandatory pre-licence assessment, the screening category, the administrative complaint under Article 103, and judicial review before the State Council**. A tilt changes which lever works; it rarely removes them all. Section 13 is candid about what this system cannot do — especially against flagship state and military projects.

How to use this guide

Read Sections 1–3 once, and Section 4 immediately — identifying the developer, the licensing authority and the assessment category determines everything else. Sections 5–7 run in parallel. Sections 9–11 are reference material. Section 12 puts it on one timeline; Section 13 tells you honestly what this system cannot do, and how to stay safe.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Before you can fight a project you must know who decides it, how, and the words the system uses. Egypt's environmental decisions run through a national regulator and a licensing authority, and are challengeable in a specialised administrative judiciary. Learn these actors and you know where to push.

The Bodies That Decide — And What Each One Controls

The competent administrative authority (the licensing body). The body that issues the **construction or operating licence** — often a governorate authority, a new-urban-communities or industrial-development body, a tourism-development authority, or a sector ministry. It must receive the environmental study **before** licensing the work, and its licence is the decision ultimately challengeable in court. Identify it early: it is your formal counterparty.

The Egyptian Environmental Affairs Agency (EEAA). The national environmental regulator, under the Ministry of Environment. It sets the **EIA rules and sector guidelines**, **screens** each project into Category A, B or C, reviews the submitted study, and communicates its environmental view to the licensing authority. The EEAA is where the technical argument is won or lost, and where a wrongly-categorised project can be pushed up a tier.

The Ministry of Environment. The EEAA's parent, setting policy and, in practice, the political weather around a contested project. Correspondence and complaints often go here too.

The Permanent Appeals Committee. Hears a project owner's objection to an EEAA decision and must rule within a set period (60 days from a written objection). It matters to you because **its decisions are challengeable in the administrative courts** — a step on the road to the State Council.

The Administrative Court of the State Council (Majlis al-Dawla). Egypt's dedicated administrative judiciary, which reviews the **legality of government decisions** — licences, permits, demolition orders — and can **annul** them. This is the single most powerful external check a community has, and much of this guide is oriented toward building a record that could stand up there.

The governorate and local authorities. Governors and local executive bodies carry out demolitions, land allocations and local licensing, and are often a project's visible face on the ground. They are a target for complaints and for the administrative record, even where the real decision sits higher up.

The professional syndicates. Egypt's engineers' syndicate and other professional bodies carry real weight and can lend technical credibility and a degree of protection to a well-argued objection. Involving sympathetic professionals through their syndicate is a recognised, relatively safe route.

Which one is "yours"? Ask: which body issues the **licence** (the competent administrative authority)? Which **category** has the EEAA assigned (A, B or C)? Has an **environmental study** been submitted, and can you obtain it? Is the developer **private, an investor, or the state / military**? And is there a **demolition or eviction** element, which brings in the governorate and a different urgency? Pinning this down is Step 1.

How a Decision Is Actually Made — The Journey of a Project

Under Law 4/1994 and its Executive Regulations the path is roughly:

1. **The pre-licence duty.** Article 19 requires the owner to submit an **environmental impact study** to the licensing body **before construction or operation begins**. No study, no lawful licence — and a facility built without one is exposed to closure.
2. **Screening into a category.** The EEAA determines whether the project is **Category A, B or C**, based on type, location and scale, which sets the depth of assessment required. Category C projects — the most potentially harmful — require a **full Environmental Impact Assessment**.
3. **Scoping and terms of reference.** For a fuller assessment, the EEAA (with the licensing authority) issues **terms of reference** describing what the study must cover. A study that departs from its own terms of reference is vulnerable.

4. **The assessment itself.** Baseline data, prediction and evaluation of impacts, **analysis of alternatives**, and an **Environmental Management Plan** setting out mitigation, monitoring and responsibilities. The EIA guidelines expressly require alternatives and a management plan — two of the most reliably winnable technical points when they are missing or thin.
5. **Public consultation.** The EIA guidelines provide for **public consultation**, and the study is required to document how concerned parties were involved and how their comments were handled. In practice the quality of consultation varies enormously, and **inadequate or absent consultation is itself a ground of objection**.
6. **The environmental decision and the licence.** The competent administrative authority **notifies the owner of the result in writing** (by registered letter), and the licence follows or is refused. The environmental approval is time-bound: if the project does not start within the licensed period, the approval lapses.
7. **Appeal and challenge.** The owner may go to the **Permanent Appeals Committee**; its decisions, and the underlying licensing decisions, may be challenged before the **Administrative Court of the State Council**.
8. **Compliance and enforcement.** The EEAA can require rectification of violations and notify the licensing authority; **Article 103 lets any citizen report a violation** to the authorities and the prosecution.

The Rulebook — The Provisions That Decide the Outcome

- **Law 4/1994, Article 19** — the mandatory pre-licence environmental study. The gate.
- **The Category A / B / C screening** under the Executive Regulations — depth of assessment by severity; the tier argument.
- **The EIA Guidelines (2009/2010)** — the required contents of a study, including **analysis of alternatives**, an **Environmental Management Plan**, and **public consultation** with documented responses.
- **Law 4/1994, Article 103** — the right of any concerned citizen or entity to **report a violation** to the authorities and the prosecution.
- **The licensing statutes** for the relevant sector (urban communities, industry, tourism, quarrying, and so on), which set the conditions the licence must satisfy.
- **The demolition, expropriation and building laws**, where homes or farmland are taken — including the requirement for lawful process and compensation.
- **Protected-areas law**, where a project touches a declared protectorate on the Nile, the coasts or the desert.
- **The State Council law**, which gives the administrative courts jurisdiction to annul unlawful government decisions.

Follow the Money — Why the System Often Leans Toward "Yes"

Understanding the pressures is targeting, not cynicism. Large projects are national priorities, tied to investment, tourism revenue, urban expansion and often to state and military economic bodies. Licensing authorities are frequently development bodies with an interest in approval. Assessments are paid for by the project owner. Where the developer is the state or an arm of the military, the political cost of refusal is high and the courts tread carefully. None of this is unlawful, but it explains why the pre-licence assessment, the category, and the administrative court are the levers that actually bite — and why arguments framed in **legality and technical adequacy**, not politics, are the ones that travel.

The Overseers — Who Watches the Decision-Makers

- **The EEAA and the Ministry of Environment** — technical review, categorisation, and compliance.
- **The Administrative Court of the State Council** — the legality check, and the power to annul.
- **The Permanent Appeals Committee** — a formal step in the review chain.
- **The professional syndicates** — technical credibility and a measure of protection.
- **The National Council for Human Rights and the prosecution** — for rights violations and for Article 103 reports, with the important caveat that outcomes vary.
- **International lenders and their safeguards** — where a project is financed by a development bank, the bank's own environmental and social standards and its independent complaints mechanism can be a powerful, relatively safe external route.

Naming and using the right body matters. Here the most consequential early judgment is usually **whether the developer is private or state, and whether the project has been screened into a category low enough to escape real scrutiny**.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns drawn from how Egyptian and comparable campaigns tend to

go, not a controlled study. Use them to prioritise effort. The single most important variable in Egypt is not in the table: **who the developer is**. Against a private or investor project on questionable ground, the levers below work much as the numbers suggest. Against a flagship state or military project, discount every figure heavily and read Section 13 first.

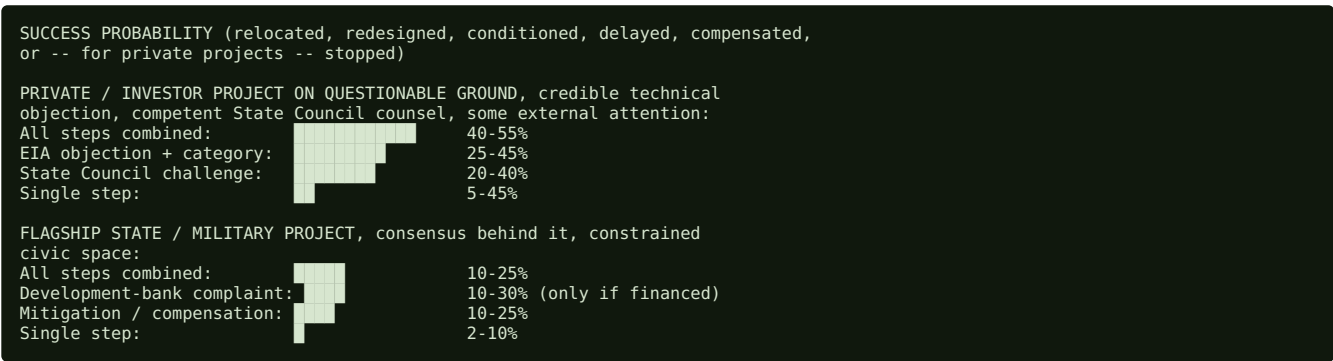
Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	5-10%	1-3 months	low	Basis for every other step
Public opposition only	5-15%	3-18 months	low	Attention; limited alone, and risk-bearing
Objection during the assessment	25-45%	during review	low	On record; can force conditions or a redo
Challenging the screening category	20-40%	1-4 months	low	Project pushed to a fuller EIA; more disclosure
Administrative complaint (Art. 103)	15-30%	1-6 months	low	Inspection; violation recorded; pressure
Freedom-of-information / document requests	15-35%	1-4 months	low	The study and licence surfaced
State Council administrative challenge	20-40%	6-30 months	moderate	Licence or decision annulled or suspended
Development-bank complaint (if financed)	25-45%	3-18 months	low	Independent review; conditions; leverage
Syndicate / professional route	15-30%	2-9 months	low	Technical credibility; a measure of cover
All steps combined (private developer)	40-55%	12-30 months	low-moderate	Relocated, redesigned, conditioned, delayed, or stopped
All steps combined (flagship state project)	10-25%	12-36 months	low-moderate	Mitigation, compensation, delay — rarely cancellation

Key insight: all steps together beat any single one — but the ceiling depends decisively on the developer. The system's strengths are real: a **mandatory pre-licence assessment**, a **screening tier you can contest**, a **statutory citizen-complaint right**, and a **genuine administrative judiciary that annuls unlawful decisions**. The constraints are equally real: a **tightly regulated civil society**, **restricted assembly**, and **state and military developers who are hard to challenge**. Where a project is internationally financed, the lender's safeguards and complaints mechanism can outperform every domestic route.

A note on cost: objecting and complaining are inexpensive. The expenditure that changes outcomes is a lawyer who practises before the State Council and, where possible, a technical expert willing to critique the assessment. Both are worth prioritising over anything else.

Effectiveness Visualization



How to read this honestly. The arguments that move outcomes here are **legal and technical, never political**. The strongest: a project **screened into too low a category** for its impact; an assessment that **omits the alternatives** the guidelines require; a **missing or inadequate Environmental Management Plan**; **consultation** that was absent or a formality; a licence issued **before** a lawful assessment, contrary to Article 19; a demolition or expropriation **without lawful process or compensation**; and a project on a **protected area** or protected Nile-strip farmland. What will not work is framing the fight as opposition to the government or its development vision. Keep every argument inside the

language of the statute and guidelines, and success becomes measurable in **category, conditions, siting, compensation and delay**.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **Legal challenges** — the assessment, the licence, and the State Council.
2. **Documentation** — because only technical and legal rigour survives review and litigation.
3. **The screening-category and consultation arguments** — high-value and reliably winnable.
4. **The development-bank route** — decisive where the project is internationally financed.
5. **Media and syndicate credibility** — which raise the cost of a visibly unlawful decision, used carefully.

Winning Egyptian campaigns combined a precise legal objection, a technical critique of the assessment, standing to litigate, and — where available — an international lender's safeguards, kept strictly within lawful and documentary channels.

What Egyptian Campaigns Actually Show

A few patterns recur. **The assessment gate is real and enforceable**. Article 19's pre-licence study is not a formality: a facility built without a lawful assessment is exposed to a closure order, and that exposure is leverage. **Categorisation is where much is decided**. Because Category C triggers a full EIA with more disclosure, a project screened A or B when its impacts are severe is both under-assessed and legally vulnerable, and the tier argument is among the most productive available. **The administrative courts genuinely annul decisions**. The State Council has a real record of quashing unlawful licences, which is why a well-built legal file is worth far more than a large but exposed protest. **Consultation is often the weak point**. The guidelines require documented public consultation; where it was skipped or staged, that is a clean procedural ground. **International finance changes the game**. Where a development bank funds a project, its standards and independent complaints mechanism have repeatedly delivered scrutiny and conditions domestic pressure could not. **And the developer's identity sets the ceiling**. Private projects on weak ground are genuinely stoppable; flagship state and military projects are usually, at best, mitigated, delayed or compensated. The through-line: **fight on legality and the assessment, use the courts and any lender, and calibrate your goal to who is building**.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

You cannot fight what you have not precisely identified. Answer five questions and write the answers in a shared document — this becomes the campaign's factual spine, and the start of a file that could one day sit before a judge.

Core Questions You Must Answer

Question 1: What Exactly Will Be Destroyed?

Get specific: exact location and extent, project type and stage, and what is there now — homes and the number of households; **Nile-strip farmland**, which is scarce and legally protected from being built over; islands, lakeshores and wetlands; the Red Sea and Mediterranean coasts, including reefs and mangroves; **declared protectorates**; groundwater and the Nile itself; air quality near industry, quarries or power plants; and archaeological or heritage ground, which carries its own protections. Obtain the environmental study if you can, and list every impact it admits, with the page reference.

Question 2: Who Has Decision-Making Power?

Identify precisely: (a) the **developer** — and crucially whether it is private, an investor, a state body, or an arm of the military; (b) the **competent administrative authority** that licenses it; (c) the **EEAA's screening category** (A, B or C); (d) whether an **international lender** is financing it, which opens the safeguards route; and (e) whether a **demolition or expropriation** is involved, which brings in the governorate and the compensation laws.

Question 3: What Specific Action Stops It?

Realistic outcomes include: the project **re-screened into Category C** and made to undergo a full EIA; the assessment **redone** after alternatives or consultation are shown to be missing; the licence **challenged and annulled or suspended** in the State Council; **conditions, mitigation and monitoring** imposed; a **development-bank review** forcing changes; a **demolition paused** or compensation secured; or, for a clearly unlawful private project, a **stop**. Map them and pursue at least two.

Question 4: When Is the Decision Final?

Diarise the deadlines, because they are short and decisive. The **pre-licence assessment** is the key window — once the licence issues, you are litigating rather than objecting. Any **public consultation** has its own dates. The **Permanent Appeals Committee** works to a 60-day rule. And a **State Council challenge** must be filed within the time limit for contesting an administrative decision — this is strict, so **see a lawyer about the deadline the moment a licence or decision appears**, not later.

Question 5: Are There Documented Financial or State Interests?

Map, factually and carefully: who profits and who is behind the project; whether a **state or military economic body** is the developer, which changes your whole strategy; whether the licensing authority is itself a development body with an interest in approval; whether an **international lender** is involved; and what public statements officials have made. Use public sources — the Official Gazette, EEAA materials, company and investment records, lender disclosure — and build a dated, sourced timeline. Where the interests are state or security, be cautious about what you publish and about naming individuals.

Output of Step 1: a one-page fact sheet with the project's description and location, the developer and its nature, the licensing authority, the assessment category, any lender, every deadline, and the interests involved.

Worked example: which lever is actually open

Suppose an investor announces a large resort on a stretch of Red Sea coast that includes reef and a fringe of mangrove. Working the questions: **Q1** — you record the reef, the mangrove, the shoreline and any nearby protectorate, from published sources. **Q2** — the developer is a **private investor**, not the state, which means the ordinary levers are fully in play; you identify the tourism-development authority as the licensing body and check the **EEAA category**. **Q3** — the decisive early fact is the **category**: a coastal resort on reef and mangrove is hard to justify as anything but the highest tier, so the live argument is that a **full Category C EIA is required**, with proper **alternatives** (including a smaller footprint or a different site) and genuine **consultation**. **Q4** — you find whether a study has been submitted and whether the licence has issued, and you see a lawyer about the challenge deadline immediately. **Q5** — you check for an **international lender**, because a financed resort brings the bank's coastal-and-marine safeguards into play. Within an afternoon you know that **the category and the assessment are the campaign, the developer's private status means the courts are genuinely open, and a lender — if any — is your strongest external ally**.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

Documentation matters more in Egypt than almost anywhere, for two reasons. First, your ultimate audience is often a **judge in the State Council**, who decides on legality and record, not on sentiment. Second, because organising in the open carries risk, a strong **paper case** is both safer and more effective than a large public campaign. A precise, referenced file is your best weapon and your best protection.

The Three Documentation Layers

LAYER 1: BASELINE CONDITIONS DOCUMENTATION

Prove what exists **before** the project, from sources you can stand behind.

Land and its legal status. For Nile-strip cases, document that the land is **agricultural**, since building over farmland is restricted by law and that status is itself a ground. For coastal and desert cases, document the shoreline, reefs, mangroves, wetlands and any **declared protectorate**, and who holds and uses the land.

Homes and people. Where demolition or eviction is involved, document the households, the tenure and the process being used, because **lawful process and compensation are requirements**, not favours.

Water, air and habitat. Document the Nile, canals and groundwater at risk; air quality near industry, quarries or power; reef and marine habitat on the coasts; and any protected species — cite measurements and published studies, not assertion.

Heritage. Egypt's archaeological and heritage protections are strong; document any heritage ground or structure affected, since it brings additional legal weight.

How to hold it. Keep a referenced file with dates, sources and, where safe, photographs with location and time. Everything you assert should be traceable to a document, a measurement, or a named expert. Assume the file may one day be read by a court and by opponents.

LAYER 2: PROJECT AND PROCESS ANALYSIS

Show whether the project is lawful and whether the assessment is adequate. Catalogue four things:

1. **The category, and whether it is right.** Establish the **EEAA screening category** and test it against the project's true type, location and scale. A severe project screened as A or B when it should be **Category C** is both under-assessed and legally exposed. This is often the highest-value single point.
2. **The assessment's adequacy.** Test the study against the **EIA guidelines**: does it contain a genuine **analysis of alternatives**, including a smaller footprint and the no-project option? Is there a real **Environmental Management Plan** with defined mitigation, monitoring and responsibilities? Is the baseline real or generic? A study that departs from its **terms of reference** is vulnerable.
3. **Consultation.** The guidelines require **documented public consultation** with a record of comments and responses. Was it done at all, was it genuine, and were the community's comments actually addressed? Absent or staged consultation is a clean procedural ground.
4. **Legality of the licence and the process.** Was the assessment submitted **before** licensing, as Article 19 requires? Was any **demolition or expropriation** carried out with lawful process and compensation? Is the site inside a **protectorate** or on protected farmland? Each is a potential ground for the State Council.

Get expert eyes on it. A short, signed critique from a qualified specialist — an environmental engineer, a marine or agricultural scientist, a hydrologist — is worth more than any amount of general objection, and routing it through a **professional syndicate** adds credibility and protection. Where a lender is involved, its published standards give you a second, external checklist to test the project against.

LAYER 3: HUMAN AND INSTITUTIONAL IMPACT DOCUMENTATION

Record the human stakes — carefully, and with consent. Document, where people are willing: livelihoods lost (farming on the Nile strip, fishing on the coasts, tourism); homes and communities displaced; health effects near pollution sources; and heritage and social fabric affected. Two cautions specific to Egypt: **obtain genuine consent before recording anyone's testimony or image**, because exposure can carry risk; and **frame harm in legal and factual terms** — unlawful process, uncompensated loss, breach of the assessment guidelines — rather than as political grievance, both because that is what the courts act on and because it is safer.

Package this layer twice: a **rigorous legal-technical version** for the EEAA, the court and any lender, and a **short public version** for careful, lawful media use.

How to Structure Your Documentation

- **Phase 1: Baseline (Weeks 1-4)** — land status, homes, water, air, habitat and heritage.
- **Phase 2: The project file (Weeks 2-6)** — obtain the study and licence; test the category, alternatives, management plan and consultation.
- **Phase 3: Expert critique (Months 2-3)** — the signed technical annex, and the lender-standards checklist if applicable.
- **Phase 4: Follow-through (ongoing)** — monitoring conditions, compliance, and the State Council timeline.

Common Documentation Pitfalls (What Fails)

- **Framing it politically** — courts and regulators act on legality; political framing also raises personal risk.
- **Missing the deadlines** — the assessment window and the strict court time-limit do not wait.
- **Accepting the category** — if it stays A or B, the project escapes real scrutiny.
- **Recording people without consent** — a safety failure as much as a documentation one.
- **Assertion without source** — one unsupported claim can sink a court file.
- **Ignoring the lender** — where a project is financed, its standards are among your strongest tools.

Documentation Budget Breakdown

Item	Low (volunteer/community)	Higher (with counsel)
Document requests & Gazette research	minimal	modest

Obtaining the study & licence	minimal	modest
Signed expert technical annex	sometimes free	moderate
Mapping & measurements	community/volunteer	moderate
State Council lawyer	—	main cost
Translation for a lender	modest	moderate

Most of this is inexpensive. Concentrate resources on **State Council counsel** and **one credible expert**.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Most of what decides an Egyptian case is a document, and knowing which ones — and how to ask — is half the battle.

The environmental study and the EEAA file. The assessment, its category, its terms of reference, and the EEAA's correspondence. Request it from the **EEAA** and the **competent administrative authority**; where a lender is involved, the assessment is often **published by the bank**, which is frequently the easiest way to obtain it.

The licence and the Official Gazette. The construction or operating licence, land allocations, and any decrees or declarations — including protectorate boundaries — published in the **Official Gazette (al-Jarida al-Rasmiyya)**.

Land and agricultural records. Documentation that Nile-strip land is agricultural, or that a site sits within a protectorate — central to the strongest legal grounds.

Demolition and expropriation papers. The orders, the legal basis, and the compensation process, where homes or farmland are taken.

Lender disclosure. Where an international development bank finances the project, its **project page** typically publishes the environmental and social assessment, the action plan, and its **independent complaints mechanism** — a rich, reliable and safe source.

Syndicate and academic expertise. Egypt's engineering and other syndicates, and its universities, are sources of technical critique and of professionals who can lend credibility with a degree of protection.

How to force a document open. Egypt lacks a strong general freedom-of-information regime, so use the routes that exist: a **formal written request** to the EEAA and the licensing authority citing the assessment guidelines; **the Article 103 complaint**, which puts the authorities on notice; **lender disclosure**, which is often the most productive of all; and, once litigation begins, **disclosure through the court**. Keep proof of every request.

Free and low-cost help. Environmental lawyers and legal-aid initiatives that practise before the State Council; the professional syndicates; university departments; and — for financed projects — the lender's own accountability office. **Where a competent State Council lawyer will take the case, that is the single highest-value step.**

Tie it to the map. The projects and units shown here are your starting index: a mapped project points you to the licensing authority and the assessment that governs it, and from there to the documents that decide the case.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Critical Insight About Organizing

Organising in Egypt requires a different balance from most countries in this series. The **associations law places independent civil-society groups under close state supervision** and makes foreign funding difficult, **assembly is tightly regulated**, and visible opposition to a state-backed project can carry real personal risk. This does not mean you cannot organise — it means the safest and most effective organising here is **quiet, lawful, documentary and channelled through recognised institutions**, not loud and confrontational.

Three principles carry special weight. **Legality over confrontation:** every action framed as a lawful use of the assessment and complaint system, never as political protest, is both more effective before the courts and far safer. **Work through recognised bodies:** a **professional syndicate**, an established environmental-law initiative, an affected landowners' or farmers' group, or — for a financed project — an international lender's complaints process gives you

standing and a measure of protection that an informal group lacks. **Protect people:** never expose named individuals unnecessarily, always obtain consent before recording anyone, and treat safety as the first constraint, not an afterthought.

PHASE 1: FOUNDATION (Weeks 1-4)

Step 1a: Establish the facts, quietly. Identify the developer (and whether it is state or private), the licensing authority, and the EEAA category, and begin requesting the environmental study — through formal written requests, and through the lender if there is one. Start the referenced file.

Step 1b: Find the people with standing. In Egypt the strongest opposition is built around those with clear legal standing: **affected landowners, farmers, homeowners and licensed users**, whose direct interest gives them both a voice and a basis to litigate. A small group of directly-affected people with a lawyer is worth more than a large, exposed crowd.

Step 1c: Recruit a lawyer and, if possible, an expert — early. The decisive early moves are securing a **lawyer who practises before the State Council** and, ideally, a **technical expert** willing to critique the assessment through a syndicate. These two relationships shape everything that follows.

PHASE 2: PUBLIC LAUNCH (Weeks 4-12)

Note that "public" here means **entering the formal process**, not necessarily a public demonstration — which may be unwise or unlawful for a state project.

Step 2a: Object during the assessment. File a specific, technical objection with the EEAA and the licensing authority — category, alternatives, management plan, consultation — and keep proof (Section 8B).

Step 2b: Lodge the Article 103 complaint. Where there is a genuine violation, report it to the authorities and, where appropriate, the prosecution (Section 8C). This creates an official record.

Step 2c: Press the category. If the project is screened as A or B when its impacts are severe, argue in writing that it must be **Category C** and undergo a full EIA (Section 8D). High-value, and reliably winnable.

Step 2d: Open the lender channel, if any. For a financed project, file with the bank's **independent complaints mechanism** (Section 8E) — often the strongest and safest external route.

Step 2e: Media, carefully. Only where it is safe and lawful, and always framed in legality, not politics (Section 10).

PHASE 3: COALITION EXPANSION (Months 3-8)

Step 3a: Broaden through institutions, not crowds. Bring in the **professional syndicates**, sympathetic academics, established environmental-law initiatives, and — where relevant and safe — journalists who cover the sector responsibly. Each adds credibility and cover.

Step 3b: Agree roles and, above all, safety rules. Decide who speaks, who files, who holds the documents, and who maintains contact with counsel and any lender. Agree explicit rules on consent, on protecting individuals, and on what is and is not published.

Step 3c: Use the international layer where it exists. A development-bank complaint, or engagement with international professional and scientific bodies on purely technical grounds, can bring outside scrutiny that is harder for a domestic actor to dismiss and safer for local people to stand behind.

PHASE 4: SUSTAINED PRESSURE (Months 6-18)

Step 4a: Litigate. Where the grounds are there, bring the challenge in the **State Council** — the annulment power is the most consequential lever you have. Mind the strict filing deadline.

Step 4b: Follow the assessment to its decision. Test the final study and the licence against the objections you filed; where they were ignored, that failure is itself a ground.

Step 4c: Work any lender relentlessly. A bank's action plan and complaints process can extract conditions, redesign and delay that domestic pressure cannot, and its findings feed back into the domestic case.

Step 4d: Use compliance and Article 103. Where a project proceeds, document non-compliance and report it; each violation is a fresh, lawful pressure point.

Step 4e: Public actions — with great caution. Demonstrations are tightly regulated and can be dangerous, especially against state projects. Where any public expression happens, keep it strictly lawful, factual and non-political, and prioritise the safety of participants over visibility. In most Egyptian cases, the courtroom and the paper file achieve more than the street, at far lower risk.

Worked example: a community that unlocks the strong levers

A stretch of Nile-strip farmland is slated to be built over for a private development, and homes on it face demolition. The instinct is to gather a crowd. What actually converts the situation into force happens differently, and more safely. First, a small group of the **affected farmers and homeowners** — the people with clear standing — comes together quietly and begins a **referenced file**: proof that the land is legally agricultural, the tenure of the homes, and the demolition papers. Second, they secure a **State Council lawyer** and, through the engineers' **syndicate**, an agronomist willing to sign a short technical note that the land is protected farmland and the assessment inadequate. Third, they **object formally** during the assessment and argue the project belongs in **Category C**; they **lodge an Article 103 complaint** about the unlawful conversion of farmland and any demolition carried out without proper process or compensation. Fourth, discovering the developer has a loan from an international bank, they file with the bank's **complaints mechanism**, attaching the same file. Fifth, they bring a **State Council challenge** to the licence within the deadline. The development is not stopped by numbers in the street — which would have exposed them — but by a **community that unlocks** the assessment, the courts and the lender: the demolition is paused, compensation is secured, and the footprint is cut back. The lesson generalises: **in Egypt you win with standing, a lawyer, a clean legal file, and the safest external ally you can find — not with a crowd.**

Opposition Building Budget: Year-Long Campaign

Low, with counsel as the main expense. The recurring costs — document requests, printing, communications, travel to the EEAA or the court — are modest. The expert critique is often contributed through a syndicate. The substantial cost is a **State Council lawyer**, which is where money should go. Keep transparent accounts, avoid foreign funding arrangements that could expose the group under the associations law, and be candid with everyone involved that the realistic outcome against a state project is mitigation or delay, while a private project on unlawful ground can genuinely be stopped.

STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES

Egypt gives communities a genuine legal route: a mandatory assessment, a licensing decision, and an administrative judiciary that can annul. Three tracks — the assessment, the licence, and the courts.

TRACK 1: THE ASSESSMENT AND THE LICENCE (where most cases are won or lost)

- **The pre-licence duty (Article 19).** Every project needs an environmental study submitted **before** licensing. If a licence was issued without a lawful assessment, or a facility built without one, that is a fundamental illegality — and a facility built without an assessment is exposed to a **closure order**.
- **The screening category.** The **Category A / B / C** decision sets how much scrutiny a project gets. Argue for **Category C** — a full EIA — wherever the project's true type, location or scale warrants it. Winning this forces disclosure and a proper assessment, and is often the most productive single move.
- **Alternatives and the management plan.** The **EIA guidelines** require a genuine **analysis of alternatives** (including a smaller footprint and the no-project option) and a real **Environmental Management Plan**. Their absence or inadequacy is a reliable technical and legal ground.
- **Consultation.** The guidelines require **documented public consultation** with responses to comments. Absent or staged consultation is a clean procedural defect.
- **Terms of reference.** A study that departs from the terms of reference the EEAA set is vulnerable.

TRACK 2: THE ADMINISTRATIVE AND CITIZEN ROUTES

- **The Article 103 complaint.** Any concerned citizen or entity may **report a violation** to the competent authorities and the prosecution. It creates an official record, can trigger inspection, and is a lawful, relatively low-risk pressure point.
- **The Permanent Appeals Committee.** The formal body that hears objections to EEAA decisions on a 60-day timetable; its decisions feed into the court route.
- **The demolition, expropriation and farmland laws.** Where homes or Nile-strip farmland are taken, the

requirements of **lawful process and compensation**, and the **protection of agricultural land**, are grounds in their own right.

- **Protected-areas law.** A project touching a declared protectorate on the Nile, the coasts or the desert engages specific protections.

TRACK 3: THE COURTS AND THE INTERNATIONAL LAYER

- **The Administrative Court of the State Council (Majlis al-Dawla).** The heart of the legal strategy. It reviews the **legality of the licence and the administrative decisions** behind it and can **annul or suspend** them. Grounds include the absence of a lawful assessment, wrong categorisation, missing alternatives or consultation, and unlawful demolition or land conversion. **The filing deadline is strict — consult counsel immediately** when a decision appears.
- **Suspension pending judgment.** Where irreversible harm looms, counsel can seek to **suspend** the decision while the case proceeds — critical when demolition or clearing is imminent.
- **The development-bank complaints mechanism.** Where an international lender finances the project, its **independent accountability mechanism** can review the project against the bank's environmental and social standards, often delivering scrutiny, conditions and delay beyond what domestic routes achieve — and doing so through a channel that is safer for local people.
- **International professional and scientific bodies.** On purely technical questions — reef ecology, hydrology, agricultural land — international expert bodies can lend weight that is hard to dismiss.

The three legal challenge types

TYPE 1: THE ASSESSMENT AND LICENCE

Article 19, the category, alternatives, the management plan, consultation, and the terms of reference.

TYPE 2: THE ADMINISTRATIVE AND CITIZEN ROUTES

The Article 103 complaint, the Appeals Committee, and the demolition, expropriation, farmland and protectorate laws.

TYPE 3: THE COURTS AND INTERNATIONAL LAYER

The State Council, suspension pending judgment, the lender's complaints mechanism, and international expert bodies.

Legal Strategy Decision Tree

1. **Who is the developer — private or state/military?** → Sets the ceiling; for state projects, read Section 13 and lead with the lender route if financed.
2. **What category, and is it right?** → If under-categorised, argue Category C first.
3. **Was there a lawful pre-licence assessment, with alternatives and consultation?** → If not, that is your cleanest ground.
4. **Has a licence or demolition order issued?** → See a State Council lawyer about the deadline immediately.
5. **Is there an international lender?** → File with its complaints mechanism; it is often the strongest and safest route.

Litigation and Advocacy Success Factors

Standing (affected owners, farmers, residents, licensed users); a **State Council lawyer** engaged early; a **signed expert critique**; a precise ground — no lawful assessment, wrong category, missing alternatives or consultation, unlawful demolition or farmland conversion; a **lender complaint** where the project is financed; and every argument framed in **legality, not politics**, both for effect and for safety.

What to Avoid

Framing the case politically; missing the assessment window or the strict court deadline; accepting an A or B category; exposing individuals or organising in ways that breach the assembly or associations laws; relying on street mobilisation against a state project; and overstating the science, which is quickly used against you.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Evidence only counts when aimed at a specific ground. Here is how the records you gathered map onto the arguments that work in Egypt.

No lawful pre-licence assessment → breach of Article 19. Feed it with: the licence date set against the absence or lateness of the study; a facility built without one is exposed to closure.

Severe project screened as A or B → wrong category; a full Category C EIA required. Feed it with: the project's true type, location and scale, and the expert view on impact.

Study names alternatives but does not assess them → breach of the EIA guidelines. Feed it with: the study's own text and a viable alternative it ignored.

No real Environmental Management Plan → inadequate assessment. Feed it with: the missing or vague mitigation, monitoring and responsibilities.

Consultation absent or staged → procedural defect. Feed it with: the (missing) consultation record and the community's un-answered comments.

Building over Nile-strip farmland → unlawful conversion of protected agricultural land. Feed it with: proof of the land's agricultural status.

Demolition or eviction without process or compensation → unlawful administrative act. Feed it with: the orders, the (absent) legal basis, and the compensation record.

Project on a declared protectorate or reef/mangrove coast → breach of protected-area and coastal protections. Feed it with: the boundary and the habitat evidence.

Financed by a development bank → breach of the bank's environmental and social standards. Feed it with: the standards, tested point by point against the project.

The pattern: **lead with legality and category, support with alternatives and consultation, evidence everything, and never argue politics.**

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media in Egypt must be handled with unusual care. Used well and lawfully, it raises the cost of a visibly illegal or damaging decision and draws in professionals, lawyers and — for financed projects — international attention. Used carelessly, it can expose people to real risk and can be counter-productive against a state project. **Frame everything in legality and technical fact, never in politics, and prioritise safety over reach.**

How Journalists Actually Work

Reporters need a hook, a document, and a credible source. Give them the assessment page admitting the impact, proof that farmland is protected or a category is wrong, an expert or lawyer willing to speak on the merits, and the deadline approaching. Keep it factual and lawful; never hand over anything that endangers a named individual without full consent.

The Newsworthiness Formula

Stakes + a credible legal or technical failure + a documented breach + a strong image = coverage. Angles that travel in Egypt: **protected farmland or coastline being built over unlawfully, a project financed by an international bank against its own standards, and a heritage or protectorate site at risk.** Economic and human-interest angles are real but must be handled with consent and care.

Know the Outlets That Cover This Beat

Map the **environment and investigative reporters** at credible outlets, the **specialist and professional press**, and **international outlets and the trade press around any lender**, which can cover a financed project's safeguards story with less local risk. Choose outlets that report responsibly and protect sources.

Building Reporter Relationships (The Key)

Give reporters accurate, sourced, lawful material and become a reliable technical contact. One trusted relationship beats a dozen releases. Offer the expert and the lawyer, and be scrupulously accurate: in a sensitive environment, one overstatement is used against the whole campaign and can raise the risk to participants.

Why media matters even when it doesn't make the front page

Coverage reaches the syndicate that will lend an expert, the lawyer who will take the case, the lender's accountability office, and officials who prefer projects not to become visibly unlawful, and it builds a dated record. But weigh every story against the safety of the people in it.

Sample Media Timeline

Only where safe: launch when the assessment or licence becomes public; refresh at the category argument, the Article 103 complaint, the lender filing, the court challenge, and any decision. Let the lawful legal milestones drive the coverage.

Media Measurement

Track coverage, but measure what matters: whether the category is revisited, whether the assessment is redone, whether a lender opens a review, whether conditions are imposed, whether a demolition is paused or compensated, and whether the court acts — all achieved without harm to anyone involved.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Ready-to-adapt templates. Keep them factual, referenced and lawful — in Egypt, tone and framing are also a safety matter. Address them to the correct body, in Arabic where the recipient is an Egyptian authority, and keep proof of every submission. Frame every argument in **legality and technical adequacy**, never in politics. Where a project is state-driven, take advice before sending anything that names individuals.

8A. Email to a reporter (story pitch)

Subject: [Project] at [location] — licensed over protected [farmland / coastline], assessment appears inadequate
Dear [name],

[Developer] is proceeding with [project] at [location]. The site is [Nile-strip agricultural land protected from being built over / reef and mangrove coast / within a declared protectorate], and the environmental assessment appears to have been screened as **Category [A/B]** despite impacts that suggest it should be **Category C** with a full EIA.

Under Law 4/1994, an environmental study is required **before** licensing, and the EIA guidelines require a genuine analysis of alternatives and documented public consultation — both of which appear [missing / inadequate here]. [Expert / lawyer name] can speak to the technical and legal merits.

[Where relevant: The project is financed by [bank], whose own environmental standards it appears to breach.]

I can share the file and put you in touch with [expert]. Documents available on request.

[Name] · [group, if any] · [contact]

8B. Objection filed during the assessment

To: The Egyptian Environmental Affairs Agency, and [the competent administrative authority] Re: Objection to the environmental assessment for [project], [location]

We submit the following observations on the environmental assessment for the above project.

1. Wrong screening category. Given the project's type, location and scale — [permanent structures / coastal works / farmland conversion] at [location] — it should be classified as **Category C** and undergo a full Environmental Impact Assessment. Its current classification as Category [A/B] under-assesses its impacts.

2. Alternatives not assessed. The EIA guidelines require analysis of alternatives, including a reduced footprint and the no-project option. The study [names none / lists alternatives without assessing them]. A genuine alternative — [describe] — is not considered.

3. No adequate Environmental Management Plan. The study lacks defined mitigation, monitoring and

responsibilities as the guidelines require.

4. Consultation absent or inadequate. The required documented public consultation [did not occur / was a formality]; the concerned community's comments are not recorded or answered.

We request that these matters be addressed before any licence is issued, and that the project be re-screened to Category C.

[Names, standing (owners/residents/users), date]

8C. Article 103 complaint

Re: Report of a violation under Article 103 of Law 4/1994 — [project], [location]

To [the competent administrative authority / the public prosecution]:

Under Article 103 of the Environment Law, we report the following violation for investigation and action: 1. **The violation** — [construction begun without a lawful pre-licence assessment / conversion of protected agricultural land / demolition without lawful process / works within a declared protectorate]. 2. **Location and date** — [details]. 3. **The legal basis** — [Article 19 pre-licence requirement / farmland protection / protectorate declaration / demolition and compensation law]. 4. **Evidence** — [documents, photographs with date and location, measurements], attached.

We request inspection, the recording of the violation, and appropriate enforcement, and ask to be informed of the outcome.

[Name, standing, date]

8D. Letter arguing the screening category

Re: Request to re-screen [project] to Category C — [location]

To the EEAA:

The project involves [describe true type, location and scale]. Under the screening criteria in the Executive Regulations, a project with these characteristics — [coastal works on reef/mangrove / farmland conversion / heavy industry / large infrastructure] — has the potential for significant adverse impact and should be classified **Category C**, requiring a full Environmental Impact Assessment.

Classification as Category [A/B] results in an assessment that does not match the project's true impact. We request re-screening to Category C and a full EIA, with the analysis of alternatives, Environmental Management Plan and public consultation the guidelines require.

[Name, standing, date, expert annex attached]

8E. Complaint to a development bank's accountability mechanism

Subject: Request to the [bank] independent accountability mechanism — [project], Egypt

To the [Independent Accountability / Complaints] Mechanism, [bank]:

We are residents / farmers / users affected by [project] at [location], financed by [bank]. We believe the project does not comply with [bank]'s environmental and social standards, in the following respects: 1. **Assessment** — no adequate pre-licence environmental impact assessment; wrong screening under national law; no genuine analysis of alternatives. 2. **Consultation** — the required meaningful consultation with affected communities did not take place. 3. **Land and livelihoods** — [conversion of protected farmland / displacement without adequate process or compensation]. 4. **Environment** — [reef, mangrove, protectorate, water impacts], with supporting evidence.

We request registration of this complaint, a compliance review, and — given imminent [demolition / clearing] — interim measures. Our supporting file is attached.

[Names, contact, date]

8F. Letter to the licensing authority before a licence issues

Re: [Project] at [location] — request to withhold licensing pending a lawful assessment

To [the competent administrative authority]:

We understand a construction / operating licence is under consideration for [project]. Under Article 19 of Law 4/1994, a lawful environmental study must be completed **before** the licence is issued, and the EIA guidelines require analysis of alternatives, an Environmental Management Plan, and documented public consultation.

On the information available, these requirements have not been satisfied: [summarise]. Issuing a licence in these circumstances would be open to challenge before the Administrative Court of the State Council. We request that no licence be issued until the assessment is lawfully completed, and that our objection (attached) be placed on the file.

[Name, standing, date]

8G. Press release (effective)

FOR IMMEDIATE RELEASE — [date]

Residents challenge [project] over protected [farmland / coastline] and inadequate assessment

Affected residents and landowners at [location] have formally objected to [project] by [developer], on the grounds that it is proceeding on [Nile-strip farmland protected from development / a declared protectorate / reef and mangrove coast] and that its environmental assessment has been screened as **Category [A/B]** despite impacts that require a full **Category C** Environmental Impact Assessment.

"[Short factual quote from the lawyer or expert on the legal or technical merits]," said [name, role].

Under Law 4/1994, an environmental study is required before licensing, with analysis of alternatives and documented public consultation. The residents have [filed an objection with the EEAA / lodged an Article 103 complaint / filed with (bank)'s complaints mechanism].

Contact: [name, contact]. Documents available on request.

8H. Letter to the professional syndicate

Re: Request for technical review — [project], [location]

To [the Engineers' Syndicate / relevant syndicate]:

We ask the Syndicate to consider a technical review of the environmental assessment for [project] at [location]. Our concerns are: [wrong category; absent analysis of alternatives; no adequate management plan; inadequate consultation; impacts on protected farmland / reef / a protectorate].

A short, signed technical opinion from a qualified member would carry significant weight before the EEAA and, if necessary, the Administrative Court. We can provide the assessment, our file and references, and would be grateful for the Syndicate's guidance.

[Name, standing, date]

Important Caveat

Templates are starting points. Adapt every one to the real project, cite the actual documents and the specific provisions, and attach the expert annex. Three things to remember above all in Egypt: **frame everything in legality and technical fact, never in politics**, both for effect and for safety; **mind the deadlines** — the pre-licence assessment window and the strict court time-limit; and **protect people** — obtain consent, avoid exposing individuals, and take advice before acting against a state or military project. Keep proof of every submission.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Egyptian campaigning rewards a small number of precise, lawful acts, and most of them are inexpensive. In rough order of impact for the effort — and read the safety note at the end before you start:

1. **Identify the developer, and whether it is private or state.** This one fact sets your whole strategy and your risk. Private and investor projects on weak ground are genuinely challengeable; flagship state and military projects are usually, at best, delayed or mitigated — and carry more risk to oppose.
2. **Find the licensing authority and the EEAA category.** The competent administrative authority issues the licence;

the EEAA screens the project A, B or C.

3. **Get the environmental study.** Request it from the EEAA and the licensing authority — and, if a bank finances the project, from the **bank's project page**, which is often the easiest source.
4. **Argue the category.** If a severe project is screened A or B, the highest-value single move is arguing it must be **Category C** with a full EIA (Section 8D).
5. **Object during the assessment**, on four points: category, alternatives, management plan, consultation (Section 8B). Keep proof.
6. **Lodge an Article 103 complaint** where there is a genuine violation (Section 8C) — it is lawful, creates a record, and carries relatively low risk.
7. **See a State Council lawyer about the deadline** the moment a licence or decision appears — the filing window is strict.
8. **File with the lender's complaints mechanism** if the project is financed (Section 8E) — often the strongest and safest route of all.

If you do only the first three, you have identified who is really behind the project, found the body that licenses it, and obtained the document the whole case turns on. That is a real, low-risk contribution.

Safety note. Frame everything in legality, not politics. Do not expose individuals. Take advice before acting against a state or military project. Nothing here is worth harm to you.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Egypt's system is tilted in two ways at once: toward development and the state, and against independent organising. Naming both honestly is what lets you choose tools that work and stay safe.

What This Tilt DOES (and DOESN'T DO)

The tilt means many big projects are driven by the **state or military**, whose decisions are hard to challenge and risky to oppose; **civil society is tightly controlled** by the associations law and foreign funding restricted; **assembly is regulated** and street opposition can be dangerous; assessments are commissioned by the project owner; and licensing authorities are often development bodies with an interest in approval. It does **not** close every door: the **pre-licence assessment is mandatory**; the **screening category can be contested**; **Article 103** gives any citizen a complaint right; the **State Council genuinely annuls unlawful decisions**; **protected farmland, protectorates and heritage** carry real legal weight; and where a project is **internationally financed**, the lender's standards and complaints mechanism provide a powerful, comparatively safe external route.

Reading Your Tilt: Responsive, Mixed, Entrenched

- **A private or investor project on questionable ground, ideally financed by a development bank.** The most workable case: the assessment, the category, the courts and the lender are all genuinely open.
- **Mixed.** A project with state involvement but also private actors, or one where the legal grounds are strong but the political weight is heavy. Weight shifts to the courts, the lender, and strictly lawful, documentary tactics.
- **Entrenched.** A flagship national or military project with full state backing. Assume cancellation is not available and street opposition is unsafe; concentrate on **mitigation, compensation, delay, and the lender route if any**, keep everything lawful and low-exposure, and build the record — sometimes the realistic win is a better-compensated, better-mitigated outcome, not a stopped project.

Documented Egyptian Dynamics

The record shows a system with real legal tools inside a constrained civic space. **The assessment gate is enforceable** — Article 19 requires a pre-licence study, and a facility built without one can be ordered closed. **Categorisation decides much** — Category C triggers a full EIA with real disclosure, so under-categorisation is both a harm and a vulnerability. **The administrative courts annul** — the State Council has a genuine record of quashing unlawful licences, which is why the paper case matters more than the crowd. **Civic space is heavily restricted** — the associations law of 2019 places independent groups under close state supervision and restricts foreign funding, and assembly is tightly controlled; organising must be lawful, quiet and institution-based. **The developer's identity sets the ceiling** — private projects on weak ground are genuinely stoppable, state and military projects usually only mitigated or delayed. **And international finance changes the odds** — a lender's standards and complaints mechanism have repeatedly delivered scrutiny beyond domestic reach, through a safer channel. The lesson: **fight on legality and the assessment, use the courts**

and any lender, organise lawfully and safely, and calibrate the goal to who is building.

Assessment Framework — Determine Your Situation

Ask: is the developer **private or state/military**? What **category**, and is it right? Was there a **lawful pre-licence assessment**, with alternatives and consultation? Is a **licence or demolition order** issued, and what is the **court deadline**? Is there an **international lender**? Is the site **protected farmland, a protectorate, or heritage**? Can we secure **State Council counsel** and a **syndicate expert**? The answers tell you whether to fight on the category, the assessment, the courts, the lender, or — for an entrenched state project — mitigation and compensation, and how much personal risk is involved.

Direct Action: Factual Information (Descriptive, Not Prescriptive)

Public demonstrations in Egypt are tightly regulated and can carry serious personal risk, particularly against state projects, and unauthorised assembly can lead to detention. This guide does not recommend street action as a primary tactic. The effective and far safer arena is **documentary and legal**: the assessment file, the category argument, the Article 103 complaint, the State Council case, and the lender's mechanism. Where any public expression occurs, it must be strictly lawful, factual and non-political, and the safety of participants comes before visibility. **Your legal file, not your numbers, is your power here — and it is also your protection.**

Honest Assessment

Tilted fights are harder, and Egypt's is tilted both toward development and against organising. But "harder" is not "hopeless": the assessment gate is real, the category contestable, the courts genuinely annul, protected land carries weight, and international finance opens a powerful external door. Concentrate force where the tilt is weakest — **the assessment, the category, the courts, and any lender** — work lawfully, protect people, and measure success in category, conditions, siting, compensation and delay. Against a private project on unlawful ground, that can amount to stopping it; against a state project, to making it smaller, slower and less harmful.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO IS CAPTURED

Egyptian development decisions are shaped less by ordinary bribery than by **structural interest and state power**: licensing bodies that are themselves developers, assessments paid for by owners, and projects driven by the state or its economic arms. Read your situation actor by actor, and — even more than elsewhere — **publish documents, not accusations**, because unproven allegations against officials carry real legal and personal risk in Egypt.

The assessment's author. Commissioned and paid for by the project owner. Signs: impacts asserted away, alternatives absent, consultation staged, a management plan that is boilerplate. Lever: the signed expert critique and the EIA guidelines, argued as technical inadequacy — not as fraud.

The screening decision. The most consequential discretionary act, since it sets the scrutiny. Signs: a plainly severe project screened as A or B. Lever: the written request for Category C, and a formal record of the point.

The licensing authority as developer. Where the body that licenses the project also promotes or profits from it, the conflict is structural. Signs: an authority that is both regulator and beneficiary. Lever: the State Council, where the legality of the decision — not the motive — is judged.

State and military economic bodies. Where the developer is an arm of the state or military, ordinary accountability is weakest and personal risk highest. Signs: opacity around ownership and finance. Lever: the lender route if financed, the strictly legal grounds in court, and great caution about what is said publicly.

International finance as a check on capture. The most useful leverage where domestic accountability is weak: a development bank's standards and complaints mechanism can scrutinise a project its domestic sponsors would prefer to wave through.

How to act on it, safely. Document from official sources — the Gazette, EEAA and licensing files, land and agricultural records, lender disclosure, corporate filings — before you say anything. Route genuine concerns through the **lawful channels**: the objection, the Article 103 complaint, the court, the lender's mechanism, and the syndicate. **Do not publish**

unproven accusations against named officials: in Egypt this can expose you to defamation and other charges, and it is both safer and stronger to let a documented, legal file do the work. The record, not the allegation, is what moves a decision here — and what keeps you safe.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

The five steps run in parallel and reinforce each other. In Egypt the timeline is driven by two hard points you do not control: the **pre-licence assessment window**, which is your best moment, and the **strict deadline to challenge a licence or decision** in the State Council. Work backwards from both, and build the legal file from day one.

Realistic 12-Month Campaign Timeline

Weeks 1-4 (Identify, quietly, and secure counsel). - Establish the **developer** (private or state/military), the **licensing authority**, and the **EEAA category**. - Begin requesting the **environmental study** — from the EEAA, the licensing authority, and any **lender**. - Identify the people with **standing** (owners, farmers, residents, users). - Engage a **State Council lawyer** and, through a **syndicate**, a technical expert. - Start the referenced file; treat safety as the first rule.

Weeks 4-12 (Enter the process). - File the **objection** during the assessment — category, alternatives, management plan, consultation (Section 8B). - Argue **Category C** where the project is under-screened (Section 8D). - Lodge the **Article 103 complaint** for any genuine violation (Section 8C). - Open the **lender complaint** if the project is financed (Section 8E). - Media only where safe and lawful, framed in legality (Section 10).

Months 3-6 (Build the legal case). - Obtain the **signed expert critique**; test the study against the guidelines and any lender standards. - Track the assessment toward its **decision**; record where your objections are ignored. - Where a licence or demolition order issues, **file in the State Council within the deadline**, seeking **suspension** if irreversible harm looms. - Broaden through **syndicates and institutions**, not crowds.

Months 6-12 (Press the courts and the lender). - Pursue the **State Council challenge**; use suspension to hold the line. - Work the **lender's complaints process** for review, conditions and delay. - Document **non-compliance** and report it under Article 103. - Consolidate the record; keep participants safe and the framing legal.

Beyond 12 months. - Litigation and lender reviews run on long timetables; sustain both. - Monitor implementation; each violation is a fresh, lawful pressure point. - Watch for **new phases, re-screening or re-licensing**, which reopen the argument. - For state projects, keep building the record and pressing for **mitigation and compensation** even where cancellation is out of reach.

Warning Signs — Act Early

A quiet land allocation or a decree in the Gazette; a project screened Category A or B that plainly warrants C; a licence moving before a visible assessment; demolition notices or survey markers on homes or farmland; clearing on a coast, island or protectorate; a development-bank project page appearing. Each is a trigger to **identify the developer and request the study that week**, and to **see a lawyer about deadlines** — because the assessment window and the court time-limit are short.

Key Principles (What Separates Winning Campaigns from Losing Ones)

Winning campaigns: identify the **developer** and calibrate to it; secure **standing, counsel and an expert** early; lead with the **category** and the **assessment's legality**; use **Article 103** and, where financed, the **lender's mechanism**; litigate in the **State Council** within the deadline; organise **lawfully and safely** through institutions; and frame everything in **legality, never politics**. Losing campaigns: fight politically; rely on crowds against state projects; miss the deadlines; accept the category; expose individuals; and treat the street as the main arena.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Real Outcomes: What Winning Looks Like

"Winning" in Egypt depends heavily on who is building, and naming the realistic outcomes honestly is the point: - a project **re-screened to Category C** and made to undergo a full EIA, with real disclosure; - an assessment **redone** after missing alternatives or consultation are exposed; - a licence **annulled or suspended** by the State Council; - **conditions, mitigation and monitoring** written into the environmental approval; - a **development-bank review** forcing redesign, conditions or delay; - a **demolition paused** or **compensation** secured for homes or farmland; - a project **relocated or reduced** off a reef, a protectorate, or protected farmland; - and, for a genuinely private project on unlawful ground, a **stop**.

What is usually not available is the outright cancellation of a flagship state or military project. Against those, plan for **mitigation, compensation and delay**, and treat a smaller, slower, better-compensated outcome as the real win — while keeping everyone safe.

Decision Point: Continue, Modify, or Reassess

Reassess honestly, and safely, at each milestone. If the developer is a **flagship state or military body**, accept early that cancellation is unlikely and street opposition is unsafe, and concentrate on the lender route, the legal record, and mitigation and compensation. If the developer is **private or an investor**, the assessment, the category and the courts are genuinely open — invest in counsel and press hard. If the project is **financed**, make the lender's complaints mechanism central. If a **licence or demolition order** issues, the clock is running — the State Council deadline is strict. And at every step, weigh each action against the safety of the people involved: in Egypt, the legal file is both the most effective tool and the safest one.

The Bottom Line

Egypt gives communities a real, if constrained, set of tools. **Law 4/1994 requires an environmental study before any project is licensed** — Article 19 is a genuine gate, and a facility built without a lawful assessment can be ordered closed. The **EEAA screens projects into Category A, B or C**, and arguing that a severe project belongs in **Category C**, with the full EIA, analysis of alternatives, Environmental Management Plan and documented public consultation the guidelines require, is among the most productive moves available. **Article 103 lets any citizen report a violation**, and the **Administrative Court of the State Council genuinely annuls unlawful licences and decisions** — which is why a clean legal file is worth far more than a crowd. Where a project is **internationally financed**, the lender's environmental and social standards and its independent complaints mechanism open a powerful and comparatively safe external route. The honest limits are real and must shape your plan: **civic space is tightly restricted by the associations law, assembly is regulated and can be dangerous, and flagship state and military projects are hard to stop** — against them, the realistic win is mitigation, compensation or delay. But private and investor projects on protected farmland, a reef, a protectorate or without a lawful assessment are genuinely challengeable, and communities that identify the developer, secure standing and counsel, lead with the category and the assessment, use Article 103 and any lender, and litigate in the State Council — all lawfully, and with people's safety first — have moved, shrunk, delayed and stopped real projects. No single step wins; the combination does. Start today by answering one question, quietly: **who is the developer, and what category has this project been given?**